

Money through the ages

From shells and grain to paper notes and credit cards, money has taken many different forms during the thousands of years that humankind has been using it. Even today, money continues to evolve, with brand new digital currencies on the rise, and electronic payments starting to overtake physical cash in many parts of the world.

Barter system

Direct exchange of goods

Where Mesopotamia (modern-day Iraq)

When c. 6000 BCE

Before the invention of money itself, people often directly exchanged items of the same value. For example, if one

tribe had more grain than they needed, they could swap it with another that had cloth to spare. Evidence suggests that Mesopotamian tribes used barter systems 8,000 years ago.

Early banking

Grain bank

Where Mesopotamia

When c. 3000 BCE

The Mesopotamians devised an early form of banking. Grain, precious stones, and other items of value were kept at temples and royal palaces for safekeeping. These items could then be “withdrawn” at a later time.



Early currency

Shells

Where China

When c. 1500 BCE

Long before the introduction of coins, people in ancient China used cowrie shells as currency. They were ideal because of their small size, which made them easy to transport, and their strength. Replicas made from other materials such as bone, lead, copper, or stone were also used.

